The Refined Hunter

All his life, Honecker was drawn to the forests. With his power base secure, more time was devoted to pleasurable pursuits such as hunting – a pastime he indulged with pathological devotion.

A former Nazi-hunting lodge built in the Schorfheide – a vast terrain of lake and oak forest northeast of Berlin – became ever more the focus of his attention. Although outwardly modest, the retreat, known as Wildfang, sat on 10,000 square meters of land and included, utility rooms, a hall for storing the game, a stone fireplace, a boathouse, quarters for guards and servants – and a miniature-sized marble bust of Lenin.

The powerful had been hunting these forests since the twelfth century. First the Brandenburg princes, then Prussian kings and German emperors, finally democrats of the Weimar Republic and then the trigger-happy Nazi minister, Herman Göring who christened his estate ‘Carinhall’, in tribute to his deceased first wife.

When out in the forests, Honecker dressed for the part, complete with knee-high boots and feathered deerstalker. His greatest triumph was to ‘bag a stag’, a creature known for its majesty and courage. Over time, he amassed a collection of thirty guns, including elegant Berettas and Brownings, but his favourite was a rifle gifted by Klement Gottwald, the leader of the Communist Party of Czechoslovakia. ‘But first I had to learn how to use such a rifle,’ Honecker recounted. ‘It’s not like you have a rifle and then you hit something. I had to learn that first. And then over time, it became a real hobby.’ Since other SED Politburo members sought relaxation when killing animals (especially Willi Stoph and Günter Mittag), male friendships developed and alliances were forged. Accounts suggest momentous decisions were made on boozy hunting trips and ideas for policy often began as small talk around a campfire. (Ulbricht preferred to go skiing. It was only when he noticed that Honecker and Brezhnev kept disappearing to